

POLITICS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

While mainstream social media sites are often thought to be politically neutral, the results mean that the users are. We analyzed Pew Research's American Trends Panel Wave 14, conducted from March 18-24, 2025, to see just how intertwined politics are with the platforms we use and accounts we're exposed to every day.



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Visualization by Morgan Murphy

DEMOGRAPHICS

Participants were largely white (72.4%, n=19,564) and above the age of 29 (with only 1,399, n=2,236, between the ages of 18-29). There was relatively even representation between major American political parties, with 21,758 (n=45,072) identifying as Independent, 29,498 (n=49,588) as Republican, and 33,873 (n=56,500) as Democrat. Both genders were also evenly represented, with men making up 44.9% (n=14,464) of the participants, and the remaining 55.0% (n=17,328) being women.

USAGE PATTERNS

Participants most often reported using the included social media sites—Facebook, TikTok, Instagram, and X (formerly Twitter)—several times a day. Of these four sites, Facebook had the largest amount of users reporting this use frequency at 42.46%. Use for X varied more than the other three sites, with a far higher rate of usage every few weeks or less (24.56) than it's counterparts.

HOW MUCH OF THAT IS NEWS?

Among these social media users, most said that they do not particularly use the included sites for staying up-to-date on news. Between Facebook, TikTok, and Instagram respectively, only 33.23%, 34.48%, and 35.4% of valid responses indicated that users get their news from these sites. This split was far more even among X users, with 41.63% (SAYING YES).

HOW DO THESE SITES LEAN?

When asked if these sites are mostly liberal or conservative, participants tended to believe that they are either mostly neutral or liberal. Facebook and Instagram were seen as the latter, with 40.37% and 46.58% respectively deeming the sites "mostly liberal". TikTok and X were seen as having no lean by 46.53% and 46.8% respectively. The most conservative-leaning site according to participants was X at 38.58%, with the most liberal-leaning being Instagram at 46.58% and most neutral site being TikTok at 46.8%.

WHICH PARTIES POST THE MOST POLITICAL CONTENT?

With regards to frequency of posting political content, participants generally reported a low rate of such behavior irrespective of platform or party; most stated that only "most" or "a little" of the content they post is political in nature. The overall frequency seemed to occur on X, with 31.46% of total responses indicating that "most" of their posts to the site are political compared to the 19.8% average of the same category across the different sites. Democrats also had the highest rate of self-reported political posting among all frequencies and platforms, with the exception of X.

WHY DO DIFFERENT PARTIES POST THIS CONTENT?

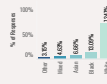
Among participants who indicated that the following were reasons why they post about politics online, unique trends emerged between sites. Across all platforms besides X (with a slightly larger percentage of Republican respondents than the other sites), Democrats most frequently stated that all motivations presented in the survey influenced their political posting.

Individuals who do not align politically with Independents, Republicans, or Democrats cited feeling like their views are welcome on TikTok (4.365%) as their most popular reason for posting politically to the site, with 11% for Independents (7.44%), Democrats most prominent reasoning was "to feel like something I should do", particularly on Instagram (14.18%). Republicans most often cited the same motivation with regards to Facebook (9.38%).

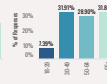
WHAT DOES THIS ALL MEAN?

As revealed by the survey responses, participants are online incredibly frequently—most reported going on at least one of the four included sites several times a day. While many did not report getting their news from these sites, most saw posting politically-centered content to some degree. It makes sense, then, to assume that many users across all included platforms, and from all political parties, are being exposed to political content shared by others (even if they don't necessarily seek it out!).

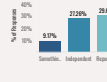
Race Distribution



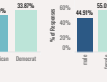
Age Distribution



Political Party Distribution



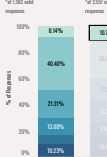
Gender Distribution



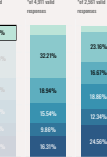
How often do you use the following social media sites?

Almost constantly, Several times a day, A few times a week, About once a week, Every few weeks or less.

Facebook?



TikTok?



Instagram?



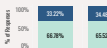
X?



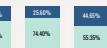
Do you get news from the following social media sites?

Yes, No

Facebook?



TikTok?



Instagram?



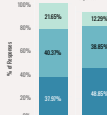
X?



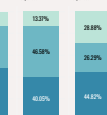
Which way do you think the following sites lean politically?

Mostly conservative, Mostly liberal, No lean

Facebook?



TikTok?



Instagram?



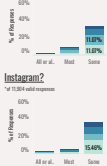
X?



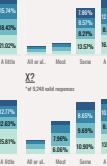
How often do people from different political parties post about politics?

Almost every day, Several times a day, A few times a week, About once a week, Every few weeks or less

Facebook?



TikTok?



Instagram?



X?



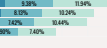
Why do people from different parties post political content on these sites?

Feeling like my views are welcome there, My posts make a difference, Politics being there

Facebook?



TikTok?



Instagram?



X?



SHOULD THIS CHANGE HOW YOU INTERACT WITH SOCIAL MEDIA SITES?

While self-reported data comes with the inherent risk of bias, these findings are still good to keep in mind when you're scrolling. Make sure you're always fact-checking posts for reliability, particularly if they don't come from a reputable news source!